

Fireworks

Non-fiction

What do the 1st of January and the 5th of November have in common? The answer is fireworks. Here in the UK, New Year's Eve and Bonfire Night are very different events, but they both often involve big firework displays. They are not the only ones either. Countries all around the world have their own reasons to celebrate, from national days to religious festivals. More often than not, fireworks really help the parties to go with a bang!

How they began

The basic ingredient of fireworks was discovered some two thousand years ago in China. One day, a cook was mixing some powders that were often found in kitchens back then. When the mixture was put in the fire, BOOM! The first gunpowder had been invented, completely by mistake.

How they have changed

Around 1400 years ago, the Chinese started using gunpowder in fireworks. At first, these were used for scaring away evil spirits but, before long, they were being used to make stunning displays.

So how do we turn a dull, black powder into a shower of multi-coloured stars? The trick is in how each firework is put together. From the outside, a firework might look like just a single cardboard tube. Inside, however, there are a number of smaller sections packed with different materials for different effects. As for the colours, they depend on combinations of chemicals.

Firework Safety

It is always better to go to a proper, organised firework display because that way, you should see a bigger show. Also, you can enjoy being with lots of other people.

If your family does decide to have fireworks at home, there are a number of important rules to follow. These are sometimes known as the firework code. Here are just a few of them:

- Keep fireworks in a closed box, ideally made of metal.
- Wear gloves when using sparklers.
- Never return to a firework once it has been lit.
- Keep animals and pets indoors as they may be frightened by fireworks.
- Do not have firework displays late at night. People who live near you may want to sleep.